

The Daily Gamecock *Opinion*

Headline Style Guide

J.C. Vaught, Opinion Editor. Fall 2025

Core Philosophy

We write arguments, not breaking news.

A news headline tells the reader *what* happened. An opinion headline tells the reader *why it matters* and *who is responsible*, and often, *what should be done about it*. We do not *only* report on the existence of a problem; we pass judgment on it.

1 The Seven Principles

1.1 Principle 1: The “No Colons” Rule

Colons are for lab reports, textbooks, and news features. They create a “Label: Explanation” dynamic that is boring and passive. Opinion headlines ought to be fluid, declarative sentences that can stand on their own. It also looks weird to have 2 colons in a title; especially since all of our columns need to start with [Column: title] or [Guest Column: title].

Example 1: Dining

Context: A writer argues that the new meal plan is too expensive and food quality has dropped.

BAD: Column: Dining Services: The new meal plan is a failure

GOOD: Column: The new dining contract exploits a captive freshman class

Analysis: The bad column was reasonably effective, but it was missing some key elements – namely, WHY the plan was a failure. The revised column title answers WHO was affected (the freshman class) and WHAT happened. This helps readers determine if the article is relevant to them.

Example 2: Sports

Context: The football team lost largely because the defense could not stop the run.

BAD: Column: Gamecock Football: Defense was the problem on Saturday

GOOD: Column: A porous defense sabotages our offensive efforts

Analysis: The bad column tells the reader which side of the ball struggled, but it does not say how or why that struggle mattered. The revised headline turns that label into a claim: the defense did not just play poorly; it *sabotaged* the offense. That verb signals blame and implies a causal chain.

Example 3: Academics

Context: The library is cutting its 24-hour schedule during finals week.

BAD: Column: Library Hours: Why they need to change back

GOOD: Column: Reduced library study hours has sabotaged our academic success

Analysis: The bad headline promises that the writer will explain “why they need to change back,” but it does not tell the reader who is harmed or what exactly is at stake. The revised headline directly names both the policy and its impact.

1.2 Principle 2: The “No False Urgency” Rule

Breaking news relies on words like “Just,” “Now,” “Recently,” or “Yesterday.” Opinion writing is timeless. If your argument is strong, it does not need a timestamp to make it relevant. Focus on the *implication*, not the *timing*.

Example: Student Government

Context: Student Government passed a bill yesterday to fund a new aesthetic garden instead of student orgs.

BAD: Student Senate just passed a bill to build a garden instead of academics

GOOD: Funding aesthetic gardens over student scholarships is a gross misuse of fees

Example: Tuition

Context: The Board of Trustees announced a tuition hike this morning.

BAD: The Board just voted to raise tuition again — third year in a row

GOOD: Tuition hikes demand an immediate freeze on administrative salaries

Example: Safety

Context: A robbery occurred last night at an off-campus apartment complex.

BAD: A robbery just happened at The Hub last night

GOOD: Recurring crime in off-campus housing exposes a failure in city zoning oversight

1.3 Principle 3: The “No Explainers” Rule

Never promise to explain something to the reader (“Why/How X happened”). That is the job of a reporter. As a columnist, your job is to deliver the verdict immediately. Turn the “Why” into a “Result.”

Example: Athletics

Context: The Head Coach fired the Offensive Coordinator after a losing streak.

BAD: Why the Head Coach decided to fire the Offensive Coordinator

GOOD: Firing the coordinator is a desperate attempt to save a failing season

Example: Greek Life

Context: Fewer students are rushing sororities this year compared to last year.

BAD: Why sorority recruitment numbers are dropping

GOOD: Declining recruitment numbers signal a cultural shift away from Greek Life

Example: Transportation

Context: The university changed the bus routes, and now they do not go to the engineering building.

BAD: How the new bus routes affect engineering students

GOOD: The new bus schedule effectively isolates engineering majors from main campus

1.4 Principle 4: The “Opinion as Fact” Rule (No Generalizations)

New writers often try to hide their opinion by saying “Students feel...” or “Many think...” This is weak. Do not report on the students’ feelings; report on the *validity* of those feelings. State the opinion as an objective truth.

Example: Parking

Context: Commuters are angry because the university oversold parking permits.

BAD: Students are frustrated and angry about the lack of parking spots

GOOD: Overselling permits is a predatory practice that steals from commuters

Example: Housing

Context: Students are scared because they found mold in the Capstone dorms.

BAD: Residents are worried about mold in their rooms

GOOD: Unchecked mold growth in residence halls is public health negligence

Example: Mental Health

Context: Students feel that the wait times for counseling services are too long.

BAD: Students think counseling services are too slow

GOOD: Month-long wait times for counseling render the service useless during a crisis

1.5 Principle 5: The “No Names” Rule (Focus on Roles)

Unless the person is iconic (The President, The Head Coach), using a specific name in a headline often alienates readers who do not know them. Focus on the *role*, the *action*, or the *impact*. The person is temporary; the structural issue is permanent.

Example: Student Government

Context: Senator John Doe voted against a bill providing free scantrons.

BAD: John Doe voting no on scantrons was a mistake

GOOD: Denying academic supplies during finals week signals a disconnect from student needs

Example: Sports

Context: The starting quarterback keeps throwing interceptions in the fourth quarter.

BAD: Smith needs to stop throwing interceptions

GOOD: Reckless quarterback play is the single greatest liability to this season

Example: Administration

Context: Provost Smith decided to change the grading scale to remove minuses.

BAD: Provost Smith made a bad call on the grading scale

GOOD: Arbitrary changes to the grading scale undermine academic integrity

1.6 Principle 6: The “Active Blame” Rule

Passive voice protects the guilty. Never say “Mistakes were made” or “Problems exist.” Identify exactly *who* is doing the action. If a system is broken, name the system.

Example: Facilities

Context: The elevators in a dorm have been broken for three weeks.

BAD: Broken elevators are a major inconvenience

GOOD: Housing neglect forces residents to live in inaccessible conditions

Example: Technology

Context: The Wi-Fi in the library crashes every day at noon.

BAD: The Wi-Fi in the library is really bad

GOOD: Infrastructure failures in the library prevent students from completing basic coursework

Example: Events

Context: The ticket lottery system crashed, and nobody got tickets.

BAD: Mistakes were made with the student ticket lottery

GOOD: Athletics failed to prepare for predicted student demand

1.7 Principle 7: The “So What?” Rule (Future Consequence)

A complaint looks backward (“This is bad”). An argument looks forward (“This will cause X”). The best headlines predict the consequence of the status quo.

Example: Academics

Context: The university is doubling class sizes for English 101 to save money.

BAD: English classes are getting too big for students to learn

GOOD: Doubling class sizes ensures the erosion of the liberal arts education

Example: Diversity

Context: The state legislature is cutting the budget for the diversity office.

BAD: Cutting the diversity budget is bad for the school

GOOD: Defunding diversity programs ensures a homogenized and unprepared student body

Example: City Life

Context: A beloved local coffee shop is being replaced by a Starbucks.

BAD: It is sad that Cool Beans is closing down

GOOD: Allowing corporate chains to dominate downtown erases the city's cultural identity

2 Approved ‘Analysis’-Style Headline Structures

These are the “plug-and-play” formulas for writing strong headlines. When you are stuck, see which of these four templates fits your argument best.

Note that if you are writing a ‘call-to-action’ piece or a ‘activism’-esque piece, then you should skip to section 3 where we go over this in more detail. This section is more for analysis-style or reflection columns and opinions.

2.1 Structure 1: The “Dead/Over” Declaration

This structure declares the end of an era, a tradition, or a strategy. It is definitive and bold. It does not ask *if* something is over; it asserts that it *is*.

Example: Tradition

Context: A columnist argues that mandatory attendance policies are outdated in the age of digital learning.

BAD: Mandatory Attendance: Why professors should stop using it

GOOD: The era of mandatory attendance is dead and that is progress

Example: Athletics

Context: The Athletic Department keeps trying to sell season tickets by highlighting championships from the 1980s, but students don’t care.

BAD: Athletics needs to stop focusing on the past to sell tickets

GOOD: Relying on alumni nostalgia to sell student tickets is a dead strategy

Example: Campus Culture

Context: Students are moving off-campus earlier and earlier, killing the traditional “dorm life” culture.

BAD: Dorm culture isn’t what it used to be

GOOD: The concept of a unified ‘campus life’ is dead to a commuter-heavy class

2.2 Structure 2: The Comparative Value (“X matters more than Y”)

This structure forces a choice between two values. It acknowledges that both might be good, but argues that one is *essential*. It creates conflict and stakes.

Example: Student Fees

Context: Student Government wants to renovate the student union lobby (aesthetic) instead of lowering the price of meal plans (affordability).

BAD: We need lower food prices more than a new lobby

GOOD: Affordable dining matters more than aesthetic renovations to meal plan holders

Example: Elections

Context: A candidate with a perfect resume lost to a candidate who actually talked to students.

BAD: Students prefer candidates who are nice over candidates with resumes

GOOD: Authentic connection matters more than a resume to this student body

Example: Infrastructure

Context: The university is prioritizing building more parking garages over making crosswalks safer for pedestrians.

BAD: Safety is more important than parking spots

GOOD: Pedestrian safety matters more than convenient parking spots

2.3 Structure 3: The Action/Consequence (“A acts as/leads to B”)

This is the most “scientific” of the opinion headlines. It posits that **Action A** inevitably causes **Result B**. Use strong, active verbs like *ensures*, *guarantees*, *signals*, or *acts as*.

Example: Housing

Context: The city refuses to put a cap on rent prices for student apartments, so poor students are dropping out.

BAD: High rent prices are causing students to leave school

GOOD: Ignoring the housing crisis acts as a silent eviction for low-income students

Example: Tuition

Context: The university raised tuition but the buildings are still falling apart.

BAD: Tuition is going up but facilities aren’t getting better

GOOD: Raising tuition without improving facilities is a breach of trust

Example: Gentrification

Context: The university is tearing down cheap local bars to build high-end luxury condos.

BAD: Building luxury condos is hurting the local community

GOOD: Prioritizing luxury apartments ensures the gentrification of the downtown district

2.4 Structure 4: The Inverse/Reframe

This structure takes a common narrative (what “everyone” says) and flips it on its head. It shifts the blame from the victim to the system.

Example: Scooters

Context: Everyone hates electric scooters on sidewalks, but the columnist argues they only ride there because there are no bike lanes.

BAD: Scooters aren’t the problem, bike lanes are

GOOD: The demonization of electric scooters is a lazy alternative to fixing bike lanes

Example: Attendance

Context: Professors complain that students aren’t coming to class, but the columnist argues the classes are boring and useless.

BAD: It’s not students’ fault they don’t go to class

GOOD: Blaming students for low attendance ignores the failure of the lecture format

Example: Activism

Context: The university deleted the designated “Free Speech Zone,” claiming it was to “protect students,” but it actually silences them.

BAD: Removing the Free Speech Zone is bad for protests

GOOD: The removal of the free speech zone is the first step in sanitizing campus culture

3 Activism & Demands

Key Principle

We do not beg; we demand.

Weak headlines ask for change (“The university should consider X”). Strong headlines mandate change by highlighting the consequences of inaction. Avoid preachy language like “Students need to...” or “You should...”

3.1 Structure 1: The “It Is Time” (The Ultimatum)

This structure is the strongest way to call for a total overhaul. It implies that patience has run out. Use it when a system is fundamentally broken and cannot be fixed with small tweaks.

Example: Policy

Context: The current attendance policy penalizes students for being sick, even with a doctor’s note.

BAD: The attendance policy needs to be more lenient

GOOD: It is time to dismantle the outdated mandatory attendance policy

Example: Business Ties

Context: The current dining vendor has failed health inspections three times in a row.

BAD: We should probably find a new dining company

GOOD: It is time to sever ties with the current dining vendor contract

Example: Bureaucracy

Context: Student Activity Fees are being spent on parties for the executive officers, and no one knows where the rest of the money is.

BAD: Student Gov needs to show us where the money is going

GOOD: It is time to audit the mishandled allocation of student activity fees

3.2 Structure 2: The Mandate (“Must,” not “Should”)

“Should” is a suggestion; “Must” or “Need” is a requirement. When targeting a specific powerful entity (The Board, City Council, The President), use “Must” to sound authoritative. Connect the action to a specific result.

Example: Tuition

Context: Tuition keeps going up, and students are dropping out because they can't afford it.

BAD: The Board of Trustees should stop raising tuition

GOOD: The Board of Trustees must freeze tuition hikes to protect retention rates

Example: City Planning

Context: Developers are building luxury student housing that no actual student can afford.

BAD: The city should make developers build cheaper apartments

GOOD: City Council must force developers to include affordable housing caps

Example: Housing Monopoly

Context: One company owns all the off-campus apartments and is price-gouging students.

BAD: The administration needs to say something about the apartment prices

GOOD: The Administration must address the off-campus housing monopoly

3.3 Structure 3: The “A, Not B” (The Responsibility Shift)

This structure is excellent for reframing a debate. Often, institutions blame students for problems (safety, trash, noise). This structure pushes the blame back up the ladder to the people with power.

Example: Safety

Context: The university tells students to “walk in groups” to stay safe, rather than hiring more security or fixing the streetlights.

BAD: Students shouldn't be the only ones worrying about safety

GOOD: The Administration, not the student body, must shoulder the cost of security

Example: Labor

Context: The university relies on underpaid graduate students to teach classes while tenured professors do research.

BAD: Grad students need more help from professors

GOOD: Tenured faculty, not graduate assistants, must lead the charge for fair wages

Example: Infrastructure

Context: Downtown roads are crumbling because of the heavy construction equipment used to build student condos.

BAD: We shouldn't have to pay for the roads the developers broke

GOOD: Developers, not residents, need to pay for the downtown infrastructure strain